

Cornell University — Information Science B.A. (Information Ethics, Law, and Policy)

Program Dossier · Prepared for Eidee Tan & Family · Fall 2027 Entry · Research date: August 15, 2026

Cornell’s Information Science B.A., taken in the College of Arts & Sciences with the **Information Ethics, Law, and Policy (IELP) concentration**, is the most explicitly named undergraduate technology-law curriculum among Eidee’s candidate schools: a computing-and-data degree whose junior/senior core is built from courses on surveillance and privacy, cybersecurity law, information policy, and fair-algorithm design ([catalog](#)). It exists because Cornell houses Information Science in the Bowers College of Computing and Information Science but confers the B.A. through Arts & Sciences — so the major lives inside a full liberal-arts degree. The single most important thing to know: **Eidee applies to the College of Arts & Sciences, not to the major**. She would affiliate with Information Science after arriving, under **published, requirements-based standards (prerequisite courses, GPA ≥ 2.3 overall and ≥ 2.5 in major courses)** — a transparent gate, not a competitive lottery ([affiliation requirements](#)). Note also that **Cornell reinstated the SAT/ACT requirement beginning with Fall 2026 entry**, so a score is required for her cycle ([testing policy](#)).

1. The university at a glance

Item	Detail	Source
Location / type	Ithaca, New York; founded 1865; “private university, public mission” — privately endowed and New York State’s federal land-grant institution	Cornell — About
Identity line	Ezra Cornell’s founding aim: an institution where “any person can find instruction in any study”	Cornell Financial Aid
Undergraduate enrollment	16,138	Cornell — About
Overall admit rate	≈ 8.4% — 65,612 applied, 5,516 admitted, Fall 2024 entry (Class of 2028); figures from Cornell’s Common Data Set 2024–25 as reported by a secondary source (Cornell’s own CDS file is a form-field PDF/XLSX we could not machine-read)	Cornell CDS library; secondary summary
Test policy	SAT or ACT required beginning with Fall 2026 entry (so required for Fall 2027); self-report at application, official scores on enrollment; superscoring and Score Choice honored	Standardized Testing Policy
SAT mid-50%	Enrolled first-years, Fall 2024 entry (test-optional cycle, ≈45% submitting): composite ≈ 1510–1560; EBRW 730–770; Math 770–800 — secondary-reported from CDS 2024–25	secondary summary
Application platform + fee	Common Application; \$85 fee (waivers via Common App criteria)	First-Year Applicants

Item	Detail	Source
Early Decision	November 1 (materials by Nov 13); decision mid-December; binding	First-Year Applicants
Regular Decision	January 2 (materials by Jan 19); decision late March	First-Year Applicants
Financial aid headline	Need-blind for U.S. applicants (“interest in or need for financial aid is not amongst the... factors considered”); meets 100% of demonstrated need with grants, work-study, and “reasonable student loans depending on total family income”; CSS Profile + FAFSA	Financial Aid — First-Year U.S.

2. The big picture — what kind of place this is

Cornell is the Ivy League’s institutional hybrid: a privately endowed research university that is also New York’s land-grant college, organized as a federation of colleges and schools. First-year applicants choose one of **eight admitting colleges** — Arts & Sciences, Engineering, Agriculture & Life Sciences, the Brooks School of Public Policy, and others — and each college runs its own curriculum and advising (**colleges and schools**). The founding promise, “any person... any study,” is not a slogan so much as an operating principle: the course catalog is enormous, and cross-college enrollment is routine.

For Eidee, the relevant structural fact is the **Cornell Bowers College of Computing and Information Science (Bowers CIS)**. It houses Computer Science, Information Science, and Statistics and Data Science — but it is **not an admitting college**; the admissions site marks it explicitly as such (**colleges and schools**). Students reach its majors from inside Arts & Sciences (or CALS/Engineering) and affiliate after enrolling. That design means a Bowers CIS degree comes wrapped in a liberal-arts education rather than an engineering track.

Undergraduate study in Arts & Sciences follows a classic distribution model, not a fixed core: **120 credits (100 from A&S), two First-Year Writing Seminars, a foreign-language requirement, and at least 8 courses spread across 10 distribution categories** — including, aptly for Eidee, “Ethics and the Mind” and “Statistics and Data Science” (**A&S degree requirements**). Distribution courses can double-count with exploration, so the overhead is real but manageable.

What Cornell is uniquely good at for the cognition → AI → law direction is naming the destination. Where most universities make a student assemble technology-law study from scattered electives, Cornell’s Information Science department maintains an entire research area called **“Ethics, Law, and Policy”** — AI governance, algorithmic fairness, privacy and surveillance, tech and law — and teaches a matching undergraduate concentration (**Info Sci research areas**). The gateway course a first-year can take in her first semester is literally titled **INFO 1200: Information Ethics, Law, and Policy**.

Music at Cornell is an academic department in Arts & Sciences, not a conservatory — there is no performance degree, but the performance infrastructure is substantial and open by audition to students of any college: the Cornell Symphony Orchestra, a Chamber Orchestra, coached chamber music, and private lessons with department faculty (**instrumental ensembles; music course overview**). Notably for an applicant, Arts & Sciences reviews **musical recordings** even though it accepts no other supplemental portfolios (**A&S admissions**).

3. The program — Information Science B.A., Information Ethics, Law, and Policy concentration

Exact name and home: Information Science (B.A.), College of Arts & Sciences; the department sits in Bowers CIS, and an identical-requirements B.S. exists in CALS (**catalog**). **Who it’s for:** students who want to study information systems

technically *and* institutionally — how they are built, how people use them, and how law and policy should govern them. That is Eidee’s brief almost verbatim.

Structure (minimum 50 credits in the major, per the [2026–27 catalog entry](#)):

Block	Requirement
Programming	CS 1110 or CS 1112 (AP credit may substitute per Cornell’s rules)
Mathematics	One calculus course: MATH 1106, 1110, or 1910
Statistics	One approved statistics course (13 options, e.g., STSCI 2100, ECON 3110, BTRY 3010)
Information Science core	Five courses: INFO 1200 (Information Ethics, Law, and Policy) <i>or</i> INFO 1260; INFO 1300 (web design/programming); INFO 2040 (networks); INFO 2450 (communication and technology); INFO 2950 <i>or</i> 2951 (data science)
Concentration	Four courses in one of the department’s concentrations (IELP for Eidee)
Electives	Three additional courses of 3+ credits each

The core is the coherence engine: before concentrating, every major has programmed, analyzed data, modeled networks, studied human–technology interaction, and — via INFO 1200 — met the legal and ethical frameworks head-on. This is why the degree reads as a designed curriculum rather than a pile of electives.

The IELP concentration requires **four courses, one from each of four groups** ([catalog](#)):

- **A. Frameworks and institutions (choose 1):** INFO 4113 Technology and Law Colloquium; INFO 4140 Law, Policy, and Politics of Cybersecurity; INFO 4200 Information Policy: Applied Research and Analysis; INFO 4250 Surveillance and Privacy; INFO 4301 Ethics in New Media, Technology, and Communication; PUBPOL 3460 Culture, Law, and Politics of Information Policy; HADM 4890 The Law of the Internet and E-Commerce.
- **B. Methods and analysis (choose 1):** e.g., INFO 4240 Designing Technology for Social Impact; PUBPOL 2300/2301 policy analysis.
- **C. Cases and topics (choose 1):** e.g., INFO 3200 Technology, Behavior and Society; INFO 4145 Privacy and Security in the Data Economy; INFO 4390 Practical Principles for Designing Fair Algorithms; STS 4040 Digital Due Process Clinic; ENGL 3778 Free Speech, Censorship, and the Age of Global Media.
- **D. Tools and technical domains (choose 1):** e.g., INFO 3300 Visual Data Analytics for the Web; INFO 3370 Studying Social Inequality Using Data Science; INFO 4300 Language and Information.

Signature sequence for Eidee: **INFO 1200** → **INFO 4250 (Surveillance and Privacy)** → **INFO 4140 (cybersecurity law)** → **INFO 4390 (fair algorithms)** — technology law taught inside a computing department, with the STS 4040 Digital Due Process Clinic available as an applied, quasi-legal practicum. There is no required thesis, but independent research and 4000-level project courses are the normal capstone route, and the three free electives let her add algorithmic depth (CS) or cognitive science.

Cognitive Science at Cornell — verified, and honestly compared. Cornell now has a standalone **Cognitive Science B.A. in Arts & Sciences** (launched as a major in fall 2022). It requires **40 credits across at least 12 courses**: COGST 1101 or COGST 2350; one statistics course; one “structured thinking/data science” course (INFO 2950 counts); one course in each of **three of five concentrations** (Language Science; Evolution and Development; Computational Cognitive Science; Cognitive Neuroscience; Mind and Culture); breadth across three departments; and 9+ credits at the 3000/4000 level, with an honors-thesis option at a 3.5 major GPA ([catalog PDF](#); [program page](#)). Declaration is essentially open: pass the intro course plus two

COGST-countable courses with C+ or better and file the form ([program page](#)). *Honest verdict:* the CogSci major is real, flexible, and computationally credible — but it contains **no law or policy component**, so for Eidee’s specific direction it works better as a second major or complement than as the primary. Info Sci–IELP delivers the technology-law spine; CogSci delivers the mind. The two share courses (INFO 2950; statistics) and combine unusually cheaply.

Labeled alternatives at Cornell: - **Computer Science B.A. + Information Science minor.** Deeper algorithms (20-course major; affiliation needs C or better in all CS/math and a **2.5 GPA across CS 2110/2112 and CS 2800/2802**, math GPA 2.3) ([CS B.A. catalog PDF](#)); the Info Sci minor is open to all non-IS majors with C-or-better coursework ([minor page](#)). Choose this if building systems overtakes governing them. - **Science & Technology Studies B.A.** — 12 courses / 36+ credits around STS 2011, with offerings such as STS 4200 information policy and the STS 4040 clinic; strong for interpretive and historical work, but technical depth must be self-imposed ([STS catalog PDF](#)).

4. How the pieces fit together

Eidee applies to **Arts & Sciences** for Fall 2027. In year one she takes CS 1110, calculus or statistics, INFO 1200, and one or two more Info Sci core courses alongside writing seminars and distribution work. **Affiliation with the Information Science major** requires: CS 1110/1112 (or AP/placement equivalent); one calculus or statistics course; **any 2 of the 5 Info Sci core courses**; grades of **C or better** in all of them; a **major-course GPA ≥ 2.5** and **cumulative GPA ≥ 2.3**. Applications are accepted on a rolling quarterly schedule (e.g., submissions by late May decided by July 1), and students may apply while enrolled in their final prerequisite ([affiliation page](#)). Her AP Computer Science A and calculus credit may satisfy pieces of this, subject to Cornell’s AP rules for her entering year.

Concentration choice (IELP) is an internal declaration within the major, and IELP courses double as upper-level major credit. A Cognitive Science double major or minor overlays cleanly because INFO 2950 and a statistics course can serve both programs; A&S caps total credits and requires 100 A&S credits, so scheduling is the constraint, not the rules ([A&S requirements](#)).

Gates beyond admission - A&S admission (Fall 2027): competitive university admission; SAT/ACT required. - **Info Sci major affiliation: requirements-based** (courses + GPA thresholds above) — published, not capacity-ranked. - **IELP concentration:** effectively **automatic** once affiliated; it is a course-selection choice. - **Cognitive Science major (if added): requirements-based** (intro + two courses, C+ or better). - **Orchestra / chamber placement: audition-based** each year. - **Private violin lessons: audition + department consent**, advanced students only, per-semester fee. - **Milstein Program (optional enrichment): competitive** (25 scholars/year; interest indicated on the Common App or spring first-year application).

5. An illustrative four-year path

Illustrative only — not official advising; course availability varies by semester.

Year	Fall	Spring	Threads
1	CS 1110 • INFO 1200 • MATH 1110 • FWS • Symphony (audition)	INFO 2950 • statistics (STSCI 2100) • COGST 1101 • FWS • orchestra	File Info Sci affiliation in spring; violin lessons if auditioned; Milstein first-year application (Dec 1) if desired

Year	Fall	Spring	Threads
2	INFO 2040 · INFO 2450 · language · distribution	INFO 1300 · INFO 3200 · COGST course · distribution	Affiliated; begin IELP topics; chamber music (MUSIC 4651)
3	INFO 4250 Surveillance & Privacy · INFO 3370 · language/distribution	INFO 4140 Cybersecurity law · elective (CS or COGST) · distribution	Summer: policy/tech-law internship or Bowers Undergraduate Research Experience (BURE)
4	INFO 4200 Information Policy research · STS 4040 Digital Due Process Clinic	INFO 4390 Fair Algorithms · remaining electives	Independent research joining a technical system to a legal regime; LSAT & law-school applications if going straight through

6. Beyond the classroom

Research ecosystem. Info Sci’s own faculty clusters in **AI ethics and policy**, **algorithmic fairness**, **privacy and surveillance**, and **tech and law** make the department itself the primary research venue; the college runs a funded summer program, the **Bowers Undergraduate Research Experience (BURE)** ([research page](#)). At Cornell Tech on Roosevelt Island in New York City, the **Digital Life Initiative (DLI)** — founded 2017 — studies privacy, AI accountability, platform power, and digital democracy and runs a public Digital Life Seminar; it is honestly a **graduate-campus lab**, so undergraduate contact is through seminars, research assistantships, and summer stints rather than daily membership ([DLI](#)). The clean undergraduate bridge to Cornell Tech is the **Milstein Program in Technology and Humanity**: an A&S four-year enrichment cohort of ~25 scholars with funded research and an **8-week summer immersion at Cornell Tech** — applied for via a Common App interest box or in the spring of first year ([Milstein admissions](#)).

Law and policy ecosystem. Central **pre-law advising** operates from Barnes Hall for all students, with additional pre-law advisors in college career offices; the team supports exploration, LSAT planning, and application strategy ([Central Career Services](#)). Cornell Law School is on the Ithaca campus, and the Brooks School of Public Policy contributes IELP-countable courses (PUBPOL 2300/3460).

Violin and music life. The **Cornell Symphony Orchestra (MUSIC 3621)** and **Chamber Orchestra (MUSIC 4621)** rehearse twice weekly under director Gabriela Gómez Estévez, and the **Chamber Music Ensembles program (MUSIC 4651)** coaches duos through octets for strings, winds, and piano ([instrumental ensembles](#)). Music courses are open to all Cornell students regardless of college, with auditions for most performance courses ([overview](#)). **Private lessons** require a first-time audition with the faculty sponsor and are limited to non-beginners ([lesson requirements](#)); as a concrete cost anchor, the Spring 2026 roster lists MUSIC 3511 (individual instruction, strings) as audition- and consent-gated, S/U graded, with a **\$616 course fee** for the semester ([Spring 2026 roster](#)). There is no conservatory and no performance degree — for Eidee’s “violin as instrument of thought” framing, that is the right shape: serious ensembles without a professional-track gate.

7. Access, feasibility, and honest risks

Affiliation is a real step, not a formality. The thresholds (2.3/2.5, C-or-better) are modest, but they must be planned for and filed; a rough first semester in CS 1110 or calculus would matter. The published, requirements-based standard is far more controllable than capacity-constrained internal transfers elsewhere, and that is a genuine Cornell advantage — but it is still a gate that Stanford- or Yale-style open declaration does not have.

“Law” here is undergraduate legal study, not legal training. IELP teaches how information law and policy work; it is preparation for law school, not a substitute. Relatedly, the human-centered core (INFO 2040/2450/1300) means **algorithmic**

and statistical depth must be protected deliberately — Eidee should spend her three major electives and free A&S credits on CS/statistics/COGST courses rather than letting the degree drift fully qualitative.

Test-cycle context. The mid-50% SAT figures above come from a test-optional cycle in which only $\approx 45\%$ of enrollees submitted scores; with testing now required, published ranges may shift. Cornell no longer promotes admit-rate press releases, and its CDS files are machine-hostile, so the family should treat the 8.4% figure as the best labeled estimate for Fall 2024 entry, not a current-cycle promise.

Cornell Tech is not an undergraduate campus. DLI is a strength of the ecosystem, but day-to-day undergraduate life is in Ithaca; the Milstein summer immersion is competitive and small. Finally, **A&S admission itself is the hard gate**; nothing in the affiliation math helps before that.

When a different Cornell path would be better: if Eidee decides she wants to *build* advanced AI systems more than govern them, CS B.A. + Info Sci minor becomes the stronger primary; if she wants mind-science first and law later, Cognitive Science B.A. with IELP courses as electives inverts the same materials.

8. Applying — logistics for Fall 2027

Item	Detail
Platform	Common Application, with Cornell Writing Supplement (college-specific essay for A&S) (how to apply)
Early Decision (binding)	November 1, 2026 ; all materials by Nov 13; decision mid-December (deadlines)
Regular Decision	January 2, 2027 ; all materials by Jan 19; decision late March (deadlines)
Testing	SAT or ACT required (policy effective Fall 2026 entry onward); self-report on the Common App or Applicant Portal; official scores required upon enrolling; SAT Score Choice and superscoring honored — Eidee's 1510 superscore is submittable as her best sections (testing policy)
Music submission	A&S reviews musical recordings (the only supplemental material it accepts) — a natural place for a short violin recording (A&S admissions)
Interviews	Not offered/required by Arts & Sciences (A&S admissions)
Fee	\$85; Common App fee waivers accepted (how to apply)
Financial aid	Need-blind for U.S. applicants; 100% of demonstrated need met. File CSS Profile (code 2098) and FAFSA (code 002711) ; published aid deadlines for the prior (Fall 2026) cycle were Nov 15 (ED) and Feb 15 (RD) — expect similar dates for Fall 2027 and confirm in fall 2026 (aid for first-years)
Milstein interest	Check the Milstein Program interest box on the Common App and address it in the A&S supplemental essay if pursuing (Milstein admissions)

9. Sources

Admissions: First-year applicants & deadlines · Standardized testing policy · Colleges & schools (Bowers CIS not admitting) · A&S admissions requirements · Cornell CDS library · CDS 2024–25 secondary summary (labeled) · Cornell — About (facts)

Program: Information Science B.A. — 2026–27 catalog · Info Sci major affiliation · Info Sci minor · Info Sci research areas · Cognitive Science B.A. catalog PDF · Cognitive Science major page · CS B.A. catalog PDF · STS B.A. catalog PDF · A&S degree requirements · Digital Life Initiative

· [Milstein Program](#) · [Pre-law advising](#)

Music: [Instrumental ensembles](#) · [Music courses overview](#) · [Individual instruction requirements](#) · [MUSIC 3511, Spring 2026 roster \(fee\)](#)

Aid: [Financial aid — first-year U.S. students](#) · [Financial aid home](#)